

River Expedition Field Collection Guide

For the paddling team · Indiana to the Gulf of Mexico · Spring

For the paddling team · Indiana to the Gulf of Mexico · Spring

This is the list of things worth bringing back, what each one is worth, what each one costs you, and how to capture it so it is actually usable. It exists because a curriculum can only teach what you manage to send home.

Read this once before you launch and once at your first resupply. Nothing else.

How to read the scores

Every item is scored on two five-point scales.

VALUE — how much curriculum it unlocks. **5** = a whole lesson depends on it · **3** = enriches several lessons · **1** = nice to have.

EFFORT — what it costs you on a hard day. **1** = you barely notice · **3** = a deliberate ten minutes · **5** = it reshapes your day.

RATIO is value divided by effort. **Anything at 2.0 or above, do without thinking about it.**

The one rule that matters more than any item on this list

On a bad day, do Tier 1 and nothing else. A team that burns out on documentation in week two sends nothing for the remaining ten weeks. Consistency beats ambition every single time. Six weeks of a boring daily number is worth more to us than one spectacular film and then silence.

The second rule: connectivity will not cooperate

Signal on the Lower Mississippi is unreliable and there are long stretches with none. **Assume you are batching everything to a resupply town.** Capture locally, back up locally, upload when you can. Nothing in the curriculum is built to require a nightly upload.

Tier 1 — do these every single day

learn.witus.online · part of the WitUS ecosystem

Generated 2026-08-05

#	What	Value	Effort	Ratio
1	GPS track or one position ping	5	1	5.0
2	The daily numbers	5	1	5.0
3	A 30-second audio note	5	1	5.0
4	One photo to a prompt	4	1	4.0
5	One trash count at camp	3	1	3.0

1 · GPS track or position ping — value 5, effort 1

Why it is first. It drives the live map students follow, the planned-versus-actual distance lesson, and the placement of every 360 stop later. If you do one thing, do this.

How to do it right

- One fix at camp each night is enough. A full day track is better, not required.
- **Record the position even on a day you go nowhere.** A zero-mile day is data, and it is the honest part of the story.
- Note the time zone once and then never change how you write it.
- A satellite messenger beats a phone here — it works where there is no signal, which is most of it.

The mistake to avoid: sending a place *name* instead of coordinates. Names are ambiguous; coordinates are not.

2 · The daily numbers — value 5, effort 1

Capture, in one line, in the same order every day: date · miles · hours on water · wind (direction + rough speed) · air temp · water temp · weather

How to do it right

- **Same format every day, even when a field is blank.** Write — rather than skipping it. A consistent line is a dataset; an inconsistent one is a chore for somebody later.
- Estimates are fine. Say they are estimates.
- Write it before you eat, not after. Nobody writes it after.

The mistake to avoid: filling in a number you did not measure. A blank is data. A guess dressed as a measurement is the one thing that makes the whole log untrustworthy.

3 · A 30-second audio note — value 5, effort 1

Why audio and not video. It survives rain, low battery and exhaustion. It records what you actually thought, not what you performed. And this catalog's lessons are audio-first, so it drops straight in.

WITUS.

River Expedition Field Collection Guide · Learn.WitUS.Online

How to do it right

• Talk into the phone at arm's length, back to the wind. Wind noise is the only thing that ruins it.

• Say the date and where you are first. Every time.

Generated 2026-08-05

• **Answer one question: what happened today that you did not expect?**

• Do not re-record. The first take is the honest one.

4 • One photo to a prompt — value 4, effort 1

One frame a day, answering a prompt we send ahead. Rotating prompts: *today's water* · *today's horizon* · *what surprised you* · *what is man-made here* · *what you ate*.

How to do it right

- Hold the phone level and shoot landscape.
- **Include something for scale** — a paddle, a boot, a hand.
- Say the date and place in the caption. Photos lose their metadata in transit constantly.

5 • Trash count at camp — value 3, effort 1

Count, do not collect. Pick a stretch of shoreline about twenty paces long, count visible pieces of human debris, write the number. Two minutes.

How to do it right

- **Same twenty paces of effort every night**, so the numbers compare.
- Note the type of the three most common items.
- Over 1,100 miles this becomes a real dataset about where trash concentrates. One count is nothing; sixty counts is a finding.

Tier 2 — do these when the day is going well

#	What	Value	Effort	Ratio
6	Failure documentation	5	2	2.5
7	360 photospheres at named stops	5	2	2.5
8	Short interviews with river people	5	3	1.7
9	Water readings	4	2	2.0
10	Infrastructure photos	4	2	2.0
11	The decision log	4	2	2.0

6 • Failure documentation — value 5, effort 2

This is the most valuable thing on the entire list and the one nobody sends unprompted. Gear that broke. A plan that fell apart. A day you misjudged the weather, the water, the distance or each other. A resupply you got wrong.

WitUS • the floating field school, Florida, rescue WitUS Outline

How to do it right

learn.witus.online · part of the WitUS ecosystem

Generated 2026-08-05

- Record it the same day, while you are still annoyed. A week later it becomes an anecdote and loses everything useful.
- **What did you believe that turned out to be wrong?** That sentence is the lesson.
- You are not being graded. Every course built on this teaches judgement, and judgement is only teachable from real mistakes. A trip where nothing went wrong teaches nothing.

7 · 360 photospheres at named stops — value 5, effort 2

At the places on the list in §"Key spots" below.

How to do it right

- **Tripod or a solid flat surface.** Handheld 360 is unusable.
- Stand still, arms down, and step out of frame if the camera allows a timer.
- **Shoot at the height a person's eyes would be.** Chest height reads as wrong to a viewer and nobody can say why.
- Note the coordinates and which direction is north.
- Overcast is your friend. Hard sun blows the sky and blackens the shade.
- **A 360 earns its place in five situations, and only five:** you are inside a space nobody can otherwise enter · the surroundings in every direction are the story · the thing itself is gone and the emptiness is the point · you are in a doorway, on a bridge, at a border · the terrain explains a decision. If none of those apply, take a photograph instead. Most places do not need a 360.

8 · Short interviews with river people — value 5, effort 3

Lock operators. Marina staff. Deckhands. Someone in a river town who has watched it flood.

How to do it right

- **Ask permission on the recording, out loud, before anything else.** "Is it okay if I record this and it gets used in a class?" Then let them answer on tape. Written consent if you can; recorded consent if you cannot. **If they say no, that is the end of it** — do not use it, do not quote it.
- Get their name and how they want to be identified. Some will not want their name used. Honour that.
- **Ask what they have seen change.** It is the question that opens people up, and it is the one with historical value.
- Shut up after you ask. The silence does the work.
- Never promise them a specific thing about how it will be used.

9 · Water readings — value 4, effort 2

Temperature, and turbidity by Secchi disk, at a fixed interval — say every fifty miles.

How to do it right

WitUS.

- **Same method, same time of day, every time.** A consistent crude measurement beats an inconsistent precise one.

learn with precision part of the WitUS ecosystem

Generated 2026-08-05

- Record where you took it, in coordinates.
- Take it from flowing water away from your own stirred-up sediment.
- A Secchi disk is a weighted white disc on a marked line; the depth at which it disappears is your number. It costs almost nothing and students immediately understand it.

10 · Infrastructure photos — value 4, effort 2

Locks, wing dams, levees, revetment, barge tows, outfalls, bridges, terminals.

Why: almost no curriculum has decent primary imagery of the engineered river, and this is a 1,100-mile transect of it.

How to do it right

- Photograph from a safe distance. **Do not approach a lock, a dam or a tow to get a shot.**
- One wide frame for context, one closer frame for the detail.
- Note what it is if you know. "Some kind of dam" is still useful.

11 · The decision log — value 4, effort 2

Once a day, one entry: **what you chose, what you rejected, and what it cost you.**

Push on or stop. This bank or that one. Portage or paddle. Buy it here or wait.

Why it is worth the effort: this is the only record of *judgement under uncertainty*, and it is the raw material for the courses on adversity, risk and resource management. Nothing else on the list captures it.

Tier 3 — plan these before you launch, or they will not happen

#	What	Value	Effort	Ratio
12	Scheduled live streams	4	3	1.3
13	iNaturalist observations	4	2	2.0
14	Fiction written from the river	4	3	1.3
15	Resupply and expense log	3	2	1.5
16	Ambient sound recordings	3	1	3.0

12 · Scheduled live streams — value 4, effort 3

Scheduled beats always-on. Three or four announced moments across the whole trip — a lock passage, the confluence at Cairo, the launch, the landing — are achievable and give students an event to gather around. A continuous stream is a battery and bandwidth problem you will abandon in week one.

WitUS

River Expedition Field Collection Guide · Learn.WitUS.Online

How to do it right

- ~~Announce the window a few days ahead so it can be built into a lesson. ****Give yourself a two-hour window, not a time.**~~ ~~**You do not control the river.**~~

Generated 2026-08-05

- Say where you are and what we are looking at within the first fifteen seconds.
- Assume it fails. Record locally at the same time so there is something either way.

13 · iNaturalist observations — value 4, effort 2

Photograph a plant, bird, fish or track and log it. It becomes a permanent public record with a verifiable date and place, which is what turns snapshots into citizen science.

How to do it right

- **You do not need to know what it is.** That is the point of the platform.
- Get the whole organism plus one detail shot.
- Log it even if it is common. Common things at a known place and date are the data.

14 · Fiction written from the river — value 4, effort 3

You said you want to send both fiction and non-fiction. **That is an unusual asset and worth protecting.**

How to do it right

- **Write the factual log entry first, then the fiction, and keep them separate files.** A factual entry and an imagined one from the same place on the same day is a ready-made lesson on the difference between the two, and it only works if we can tell which is which.
- Label every fiction file `FICTION` in the filename. Not once, every time.
- Do not fictionalise a real named person you met.

15 · Resupply and expense log — value 3, effort 2

What you bought, where, what it cost. Honest numbers including the ones that went wrong.

16 · Ambient sound — value 3, effort 1

Sixty seconds, phone still, no talking. Dawn. A passing tow. Rain on the tent. The lock gates.

Why it scores well: the lessons are audio-first, so ambient sound is directly usable rather than decorative. High ratio, and easy to forget.

Key spots to document

Prioritised. If the trip compresses, protect the ones marked **critical**.

Place	Why it matters	Capture
learn.witus.online · part of the WitUS ecosystem The launch point	The "before" frame the whole series opens on	Generated 2026-08-05 360 · photo · audio
Wabash River, first days	Headwaters character; small-river scale before it all changes	photo · audio
Wabash–Ohio confluence	Where a small river becomes a big one. Scale change is visible	critical · 360 · photo
Ohio River crossing, Indiana–Kentucky shore to shore	The freedom line. People crossed this water north to be free; you are going the other way. The single most important frame of the trip	critical · 360 both banks · audio reflection
Madison, Indiana	Underground Railroad crossing point and network hub	360 · photo · interview if possible
New Albany / Louisville area	The Falls of the Ohio; a crossing point and a navigation obstacle	photo · infrastructure
Any lock passage	Nothing else shows the engineered river so plainly	critical · video from a safe distance · audio of the gates
Cairo, Illinois — Ohio meets Mississippi	The hinge of the whole route: two rivers, and a town with its own hard history	critical · 360 · photo · audio
First Lower Mississippi camp	The river changes character completely below Cairo	360 · audio
A wing dam / revetment stretch	The river as a managed machine	photo
A working river town	Economy, resupply, people	interview · photo
Natchez, Mississippi	A principal market of the domestic slave trade. "Sold down the river" means this water and these ports	critical · 360 · photo
Baton Rouge industrial corridor	Where the river's economy is most visible	photo · infrastructure
New Orleans	The largest slave market in the country, and the last city on the river	critical · 360 · photo
The Gulf — the end	The arrival, and the water the whole watershed drains into	critical · 360 · photo · audio

On the historical stops specifically

Some of these places carry a history of people being bought, sold and separated, and of people risking their lives to cross a river to be free. **Document them plainly.** No staging, no dramatic posing, no performance of feeling. A steady frame of the actual place, the coordinates, the date, and if you want, a quiet audio note about what it was like to be there. The record does the work. Anything more gets in its way.

Practical notes

learn.witus.online · part of the WitUS ecosystem

Generated 2026-08-05

- **Back up at every resupply.** Two copies, two places. A single dropped phone should not cost the whole trip.
- **One naming convention, agreed before you launch**, e.g. `YYYY-MM-DD_place_type_01`. Rename nothing later.
- **Charge order when power is short:** satellite messenger, then phone, then camera. In that order, every time.
- **Consent is not retroactive.** If you did not get it on the day, we cannot use it.
- **Nothing on this list is worth an injury or a citation.** Skip any item rather than approach a tow, a lock, a dam, private property or a stranger who does not want to talk. There is no shot on this list that is worth a bad outcome.

Questions for the team before launch

1. What is the planned launch date and the rough schedule?
2. Which of these can you realistically commit to daily?
3. What gear do you already have — 360 camera, satellite messenger, water thermometer?
4. Who on the team owns documentation, so it is somebody's actual job rather than everybody's afterthought?